









# Russia makes Donbas Region a key condition for talks with Ukraine

IITM Bureau

On 23 January 2026, Russia said it would not withdraw its demand that Ukraine pull its forces out of the eastern Donbas region, ahead of planned three-way talks involving officials from Russia, Ukraine and the United States in the United Arab Emirates. The talks are expected to take place later in the day in Abu Dhabi.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that the issue of territory remains the main point of disagreement and will be a key part of the discussions. The talks could mark the first direct and public negotiations between Moscow and Kyiv since the start of



renewed peace efforts Mr. Zelenskyy in Dabacked by U.S. Pres- vos and comes just ident Donald Trump hours after U.S. en- to end the nearly voy Steve Witkoff four-year-long war. held late-night talks Senior-level delega- with Russian Pres- tions from all three- ident Vladimir Pu- countries are trav- tin in the Kremlin. elling to Abu Dha- bi for the talks. Despite growing dip- lomatic activity in re- cent weeks, Russia and Ukraine continue to hold sharply different

positions, especially on territorial issues. Moscow has repeatedly said that Ukraine must give up control of the Donbas region, which includes parts of eastern Ukraine currently under Russian occupation. Russia, which launched its invasion of Ukraine in 2022, has described its demand as essential for any peace agreement. Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said Ukrainian armed forces must leave Donbas, calling it a key condition for progress in talks.

He added that Russia's position on the issue has not changed. President Zelenskyy, however, rejected the idea of ceding territo-

ry. He said that land remains the central issue in the conflict and warned that giving up territory would only encourage further aggression from Russia. Ukraine has made it clear that it will not accept any peace deal that does not ensure its long-term security. As diplomatic efforts intensify, the gap between the two sides remains wide.

While the talks in Abu Dhabi signal a renewed attempt to find a political solution, analysts say meaningful progress will depend on whether both sides are willing to compromise on the sensitive issue of territory.

# U.S. Withdrawal from the World Health Organization

IITM Bureau

On January 20, 2025, President Trump signed Executive Order 14155 formally initiating the United States' withdrawal from the World Health Organization (WHO). This decision was driven by profound failures in the WHO's handling of the COVID-19 pandemic originating in Wuhan, China; its persistent refusal to implement necessary reforms; and its lack of accountability, transparency, and independence.

In fulfillment of this directive and following the required one-year notice period, the United States Government formally exited from WHO on January 22, 2026. To fulfill Presi-

dent Trump's Executive Order, the United States Government has taken the actions:

All U.S. government funding to the WHO has been terminated, U.S. personnel and contractors assigned to or embedded with the WHO have been recalled from the WHO headquarters in Geneva, Switzerland and WHO offices worldwide, Hundreds of U.S. engagements with WHO have been suspended or discontinued and The U.S. has ceased official participation in WHO-sponsored committees, leadership bodies, governance structures, and technical working groups. Withdrawal from WHO has been a

stated priority for the Trump Administration since 2020. During his first term, President Trump sought to withdraw the U.S. from WHO over its response to COVID-19. Following its withdrawal from the WHO, the U.S. remains the world's leading authority in public health.

The U.S. will continue to ensure rapid detection and response to infectious disease outbreaks, strengthen global biosecurity coordination, and drive health innovation. Through targeted global cooperation, these efforts will protect Americans while delivering shared security and measurable benefits to U.S. allies.

# Bangladesh expresses shock, grievance over Sheikh Hasina's Delhi press event

Anjali Yadav

On 23 January 2026, Russia said it would not withdraw its demand that Ukraine pull its forces out of the eastern Donbas region, ahead of planned three-way talks involving officials from Russia, Ukraine and the United States in the United Arab Emirates. The talks are expected to take place later in the day in Abu Dhabi. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that the issue of territory remains the main point of disagreement and will be a key part of the discussions. The talks could mark the first direct and



public negotiations between Moscow and Kyiv since the start of renewed peace efforts backed by U.S. President Donald Trump to end the nearly four-year-long war. Senior-level delegations from all three countries are traveling to Abu Dhabi for the talks. The meeting follows President Trump's recent dis-

Moscow has repeatedly said that Ukraine must give up control of the Donbas region, which includes parts of eastern Ukraine currently under Russian occupation. Russia, which launched its invasion of Ukraine in 2022, has described its demand as essential for any peace agreement. Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said Ukrainian armed forces must leave Donbas, calling it a key condition for progress in talks. He added that Russia's position on the issue has not changed. President Zelenskyy, however, rejected the idea of ceding territory. He said that land

remains the central issue in the conflict and warned that giving up territory would only encourage further aggression from Russia. Ukraine has made it clear that it will not accept any peace deal that does not ensure its long-term security. As diplomatic efforts intensify, the gap between the two sides remains wide. While the talks in Abu Dhabi signal a renewed attempt to find a political solution, analysts say meaningful progress will depend on whether both sides are willing to compromise on the sensitive issue of territory.

# India not on list as Trump unveils 'Board of Peace' with 19 Nations

U.S. President Donald Trump inaugurated his proposed Board of Peace; an international body aimed at helping maintain a ceasefire in Israel's war with Hamas on 22nd January 2026. Mr. Trump claimed that there is wide global interest in the initiative, even though several close U.S. allies chose not to participate. The ceremony was held on the sidelines of the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland. Representatives from 19 countries, along with the United States, attended the event. India was among the countries not present

at the inauguration. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was invited to join the Board, but India has not yet taken a decision on participation, according to people familiar with the matter. Pakistan, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates were among the countries that accepted Mr. Trump's invitation. Mr. Trump stated that 59 countries have agreed to be part of the Board, though only 19 sent representatives to the launch event. Addressing the gathering, he described the participants as "the most powerful people in the world" and said the initiative was

meant to serve global interests, not just those of the United States. "This is not for the United States alone. This is for the world," Mr. Trump said, adding that the Board's role could expand beyond Gaza if it proves successful. The event also included an announcement by Ali Shaath, a former Palestinian Authority official from Gaza. He said the Rafah border crossing between Gaza and Egypt will reopen in both directions next week. The crossing will be overseen by a Palestinian committee operating under U.S. supervision.

# Cuba faces deep Energy and Food Crisis as Venezuelan Oil Support Collapses

IITM Bureau

Cuba is navigating another delicate moment in its recent history after the capture of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro by U.S. forces on January 3, 2026. The operation that removed him from Caracas and left him facing a court in New York killed 32 Cuban soldiers, part of Maduro's praetorian guard, and abruptly dismantled the island's main economic lifeline. The blow comes amid an energy and health crisis already considered the worst in decades and one that could now deepen rapidly. Cuba is struggling with a worsening energy and food crisis after a long decline in oil supplies from Venezuela,



its closest ally for more than two decades. Venezuela's oil industry has weakened significantly, reducing the amount of fuel it sends to the Caribbean island. At its peak, Venezuela supplied Cuba with most of its imported oil, but this has steadily fallen in recent years due to Venezuela's own economic turmoil and political pressure from the United States. The oil shipments that once

flowed under preferential agreements have nearly stopped. Venezuela's production has shrunk as its state oil company, PDVSA, has struggled with low output and sanctions, leaving Cuba without the fuel it needs for power generation, transportation, and food production. Without reliable fuel, power outages have become more frequent and longer, leaving many ar-

eas without electricity for much of the day. This energy shortage has a direct effect on food security. Farms and food processing facilities rely on fuel for tractors, irrigation, and refrigeration. With fuel scarce, agricultural production has sharply declined, and food preservation has become difficult or impossible. As a result, basic food supplies have become limited, prices have soared, and many Cubans struggle to access sufficient nutrition. Experts warn that the crisis goes beyond temporary shortages. With no oil coming from Venezuela and alternative imports from countries like Mexico limited, Cuba faces

# UN Declares 2026 International Year for Rangelands and Pastoralists

IITM Bureau

The United Nations has declared 2026 as the 'International Year for Rangelands and Pastoralists', a landmark decision aimed at spotlighting some of the world's most overlooked yet vital ecosystems. The announcement addresses a critical imbalance in global climate action: while forests receive disproportionate attention and funding, grasslands and savannahs, equally critical for carbon sequestration, biodiversity conservation, and climate resilience, remain marginalized in international climate negotiations and national climate strategies.



This UN declaration represents a pivotal moment in rebalancing climate action toward comprehensive ecosystem protection, recognizing that effective climate mitigation requires attention to all biomes, not merely forests. The International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists will feature awareness campaigns explaining what rangelands are—in plain language and

images—along with workshops, studies, and events on sustainable grazing, restoration, mobility, and land access. Many initiatives aim to highlight how rangeland ecosystems contribute to food security and climate resilience. A key goal of IYRP 2026 is to elevate traditional pastoral knowledge alongside modern range science and advocate for policies.



## Youth as the Architects of a Developed and Sustained India

Lochan Chugh

The future of India depends on how the youth act today. At a time when young people are still pursuing their education, this is a crucial period for them to work on developing their skills to build a fulfilling and successful career in the future. Skill development is beneficial not only for their personal growth but also for the growth and progress of the country. Nowadays, skills matter more than degrees. To survive in a competitive environment, we must acquire relevant skills; failure to do so may result in difficulties in securing employment in the future, which would hinder the vision of a developed and sustainable

India. To make India a successful and developed nation, we must begin this process today, as progress takes time and effort. Youth is the generation that will shape the future, and sustained hard work is required from now onwards to ensure national success. In the coming years, we may witness the emergence of many new technologies that do not exist today. To adapt to a technology-driven and internet-based environment, it is essential to start working hard and building skills today. For example, artificial intelligence (AI) emerged only a few years ago, and in a short period, it has begun competing with humans in various job sectors. We do not know how far AI will



advance in the future; it may become powerful enough to replace many human jobs rapidly.

Therefore, skill development is essential, as technologies like AI can replace those who are not adequately skilled. More technologies similar to AI may emerge in the future, which may threaten certain jobs. It is our responsibility to safeguard our careers by acquiring relevant skills today, or else

face the consequences later. Ultimately, skill development is about empowering ourselves, securing our jobs, and contributing to the nation's progress, helping India move another step closer to becoming a developed and sustainable country. In addition to technical expertise, young people must also focus on developing soft skills such as communication, leadership, teamwork, adaptability and critical thinking.

These skills enhance employability and help individuals navigate dynamic work environments with confidence. The government's initiatives like Skill India and Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana aim to equip youth with industry-relevant competencies, but the true transformation depends on individual commitment and continuous learning. By embracing lifelong learning, innovation and a growth mindset, India's youth can not only secure their own futures but also drive economic growth, social development and global competitiveness for the nation. A skilled and future-ready youth population is the strongest foundation for building a self-reliant and developed India.

## Body Positivity — Acceptance, Not Another Standard

Ms. Jyoti B

In recent years, the phrase \*body positivity\* has become a widely used slogan across social media platforms, advertising campaigns, and influencer culture. What began as a meaningful social movement has gradually transformed into a trending hashtag. At its heart, however, the idea was never about trends. It carried a simple yet powerful message: every person, regardless of shape, size, colour, or physical ability, deserves dignity, respect, and freedom from shame. The movement emerged as a response to decades of narrow beauty standards promoted by fashion industries, films, and popular culture. It sought to challenge unrealistic ideals and amplify the voices of individuals who were mocked, marginalised, or excluded because their bodies did not fit conventional norms. Originally, body positivity focused on inclusivity. It created space for people with



disabilities, stretch marks, acne, scars, different body sizes, and diverse skin tones to feel seen and accepted. It questioned why society equated thinness with success, fairness with beauty, and perfection with worth. In doing so, it encouraged conversations about self-esteem, mental health, and the harmful impact of body shaming. For many, the movement became a source of empowerment and healing. Yet, as the concept gained popularity, misunderstandings began to surround it. Public debates often frame body positivity as a conflict between "health" and "acceptance." Critics sometimes argue that it promotes unhealthy lifestyles or

as "self-love" often present another form of perfection — confident, flawless, and aesthetically pleasing. Filters, strategic lighting, and selective representation create the illusion of authenticity while maintaining polished standards. Ironically, this can generate a new kind of pressure: the expectation to appear effortlessly confident and perfectly imperfect. Instead of removing insecurity, it sometimes reshapes it.

True body positivity is far less glamorous and far more humane. It is not about loving every inch of oneself every single day. It acknowledges that self-acceptance can be inconsistent and that confidence fluctuates. It allows people to have bad days without self-hatred. It permits someone to exercise for health rather than approval, to wear comfortable

clothes rather than fashionable ones, and to prioritise well-being over validation. It promotes the freedom to exist without constant comparison.

Ultimately, the real goal of body positivity is not perfection under a new name. It is the quiet liberation from shame. It is the understanding that human worth cannot be measured in inches, kilograms, or likes. When stripped of commercial influence and online performance, the movement returns to its core principle: every body deserves respect — simply because it is human. In a world driven by appearance and approval, this reminder is both radical and necessary. By returning to empathy, compassion, and realistic expectations, society can reshape beauty standards into something healthier and more inclusive.

## Decoding Budget 2026-27: Delivering clarity, balance, and a long-term vision

-Dr. Rajnesh Kumar Pandey



Announced against the backdrop of heightened geopolitical tensions, the Union Budget 2026–27 carried expectations of reinforcing India's global standing especially in light of recently concluded Foreign Trade Agreements. The Budget 2026 continues to advance India's long term strategic narrative: strengthening manufacturing as the core engine of growth while simultaneously expanding the country's capabilities in services and digital trade.

### Manufacturing - The anchor of India's growth story

The Finance Minister reaffirmed the centrality of manufacturing to India's economic strategy. Large scale investments in textiles, semiconductors, rare earth mining, infrastructure, and MSME development signal the Government's intent to build resilient, future ready industrial capacity. These interventions align strongly with India's aspiration to emerge as a global manufacturing hub.

### A renewed push to build a global scale services economy

Complementing manufacturing, the Budget underscores the Sankalp for accelerating and sustaining economic growth, fulfilling citizen aspirations, and advancing the vision of Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas within the framework of the three Kartavyas. This focus manifests in initiatives aimed at strengthening the services ecosystem and positioning India deeper within global value chains.

Several targeted interventions demonstrate this intent. In a major relief to the IT sector, the Government has introduced several tax reforms, including but not limited to consolidating services under a single category of IT Services with a common safe harbour margin of 15.5 percent, increasing the safe harbour threshold from 300 crore to 2,000 crore to ease compliance for large taxpayers, and introducing tax holidays until 2047 for foreign companies offering cloud services through India based data centres, with a 15 percent safe harbour for related entities providing supporting data-center operations. These key reforms would aid in creating long term policy predictability and reinforce India's digital infrastructure competitiveness.

As regards providing a push to the creative industries, establishment of AVGC Content Creator Lab in schools and colleges is likely to accelerate skill development in animation, gaming, VFX, and digital content creation industries which are already experiencing exponential global demand. In terms of alleviating the tourism and hospitality needs of India, a National Institute of Hospitality is proposed which would integrate academia, industry, and the Government.

With education and healthcare forming the backbone of any resilient economy, the Budget's initiatives—such as the creation of a High Powered "Education to Employment and Enterprise" Standing Committee and the upgrading of existing institutions alongside the establishment of new centers for training Allied Health Professionals—represent critical forward looking interventions. These measures are expected to significantly narrow the skill gap by aligning academic curricula with evolving industry needs, ensuring that learners acquire job-ready competencies. Together, they will not only enhance employability but also strengthen the quality and preparedness of India's future workforce, positioning the country to meet the growing demands of a rapidly transforming economic landscape.

### Bolstering trust based governance and introducing specific customs reforms

Reflecting a clear shift from policing to facilitating trade, the Budget introduces a series of trust based governance measures aimed at enhancing efficiency, predictability, and transparency within customs processes. Key reforms include the extension of the duty deferral period for Tier 2 and Tier 3 AEOs from the current 15 days to 30 days, providing businesses with improved cash flow flexibility and reduced working capital strain. Additionally, the validity of binding advance rulings has been increased from 3 to 5 years, offering greater certainty to importers and exporters in planning their tax positions. The Government has also proposed recognizing regular, compliant importers within customs risk assessment systems, thereby reducing repetitive verification and enabling faster cargo clearance for trusted entities in addition to streamlining the overall Customs Integrated System.

It is also noteworthy that the Budget continues to advance India's agenda of becoming a more attractive investment destination. Key measures include permitting Persons Resident outside India (PROIs) to invest in listed Indian equities through the Portfolio Investment Scheme, rationalizing TDS/TCS rates to reduce compliance burden, and decriminalizing procedural lapses such as non-production of books of account or delays in tax deduction payments.

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## IITM School of Mass Communication Hosts Winter School 2026 on “AI and the Future of Media”

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The IITM School of Mass Communication successfully conducted its Winter School 2026 from January 5 to January 10, 2026, centered on the theme “AI and the Future of Media.” The six-day academic program brought together industry experts, media professionals, and students to explore how artificial intelligence is reshaping storytelling, journalism, advertising, and communication strategies in the rapidly evolving digital media ecosystem. The Winter School began with an intensive Day 1 session led by Mr. Pankaj Yadav, Creative Director at Imaginis Productions Pvt. Ltd. The session laid a strong creative foundation by introducing students to Generative AI and its application in cinematic advertising. Participants engaged in hands-on learning, particularly in prompt engineering, enabling them to translate complex ideas into visually compelling, brand-specific content. On Day 2, the focus shifted to the transformation of modern newsrooms. The discussions highlighted how AI is influencing news gathering, verification, and distribution while addressing critical ethical concerns in AI-assisted journalism. Students gained practical exposure to AI-driven newsroom workflows and



developed essential media literacy skills to identify deepfakes and ensure responsible reporting. Day 3 delved deeper into the technical and ethical dimensions of artificial intelligence under the guidance of Mr. Manoj Kumar Tripathi. Recognising the rising challenge of AI-generated misinformation, the session trained students in advanced digital forensic tools.

The day reinforced the idea that journalists of the future must act as “guardians of truth,” equipped not only to report but also to verify information with forensic accuracy. The programme continued on Day 4 with a dedicated session on AI tools in filmmaking and visual media. Independent filmmaker Mr. Bharat Parmar provided valuable insights into how AI

is influencing every stage of filmmaking from pre-production planning to post-production workflows. Through real-world examples, students learned how technology can enhance creativity while keeping the filmmaker’s vision at the centre. On Day 5, the Winter School featured an engaging session on AI and Advertising led by Mr. Pradeep Singh, Marketing Communication Expert. The Winter School concluded with a powerful final session by Ms. Vertika Saxena, DGM Marketing Communications at Denave. Focusing on communication strategy and industry readiness

## BBA Student from Department of Management Studies, IITM Shines at Startup Yuva Festival 2026

Kartik Chandel

The Department of Management Studies (BBA) at the Institute of Information Technology & Management (IITM) proudly announces that Ms. Harnoor Kaur, a first-year BBA student, has achieved a significant milestone by participating in the Startup Yuva Festival 2026 and earning national recognition for her entrepreneurial venture. Ms. Harnoor Kaur showcased her startup Nibbliss at the Startup Yuva Festival, where she presented a wellness granola bar designed to help manage hormonal imbalance and provide relief from period cramps and mood swings. The startup was short-



listed among the Top 60, receiving an opportunity to showcase the product, and was also recognized in the Top 100 startups, securing a grant of 1 lakh out of 1,000+ startups across Delhi. The Department of Management Studies (BBA) extends its heartfelt congratulations to Ms. Harnoor Kaur on this outstanding accomplishment and wishes her continued growth and success in her entrepreneurial journey ahead.

## Department of Management Studies, IITM Hosts FDP on Research Idea to Analysis

Ananya Manchanda

The Department of Management Studies at the Institute of Information Technology & Management (IITM) organized an intensive Faculty Development Program (FDP) from 6th to 10th January 2026, aimed at strengthening the research capabilities of newly appointed and early-career faculty members. Designed as a highly practical and tool-oriented program, the FDP focused on guiding participants through the complete research journey from idea conceptualization to analysis and reporting. The FDP was structured across five focused days, each addressing a critical stage of the research



process. Day 1 laid the foundation by helping participants transform broad topics into well-defined problem statements, research questions, and clear research objectives. The session emphasized clarity of thought and methodological rigor as the backbone of quality research. Building on this foundation, Day 2 introduced participants to AI-assisted literature review workflows. Faculty members were

trained in systematic searching, screening, synthesis, and responsible citation practices, enabling them to manage academic literature efficiently while maintaining ethical research standards. On Day 3, participants explored bibliometric analysis using VOS viewer, where they learned to map research trends, identify thematic clusters, and locate research gaps. This hands-on session provided valuable in-

sights into positioning research within existing scholarly conversations. The programme advanced to quantitative analysis on Day 4 with an in-depth introduction to Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM). Participants gained practical exposure to measurement and structural models, bootstrapping techniques, and result interpretation, strengthening their analytical competence. Day 5 focused on qualitative research methods using NVivo. The Department of Management Studies extends its sincere appreciation to all resource persons and participants for their active collaborative.

IITM Bureau

Students of the Bachelor of Arts in Journalism and Mass Communication (BAJMC) participated in an educational visit to the Book Fair on January 16, 2026, where they experienced the dynamic intersection of literature, media, and public engagement. The visit offered students an opportunity to step beyond the classroom and engage directly with the vibrant world of books, ideas, and conversations. During the visit, students actively interacted with visitors, authors, publishers, and exhibitors, gaining valuable insights into the functioning of the literary and publishing ecosystem. Conversations with authors



allowed students to understand the creative process behind storytelling, while interactions with publishers and exhibitors provided exposure to the business, promotion, and distribution of written content. The Book Fair served as a live learning environment where students observed media interactions, audience behaviour, and the role of communication in shaping public discourse. Through

informal discussions, observations, and exchanges, students developed a deeper understanding of how stories are created, presented, and received by diverse audiences. The experience also helped students appreciate the power of storytelling as a tool for communication, influence, and cultural connection. Engaging with a wide range of genres, ideas, and perspectives encourages curiosity and

critical thinking, both of which are essential skills for aspiring media professionals. Such field visits play an important role in strengthening practical learning for BAJMC students. By connecting theoretical knowledge with real-world experiences, students gain a broader perspective of the media landscape and develop the confidence to interact in professional environments. The Book Fair visit proved to be an enriching and inspiring experience, reinforcing the importance of experiential learning in media and communication education and encouraging students to explore, question, and engage with the world of ideas beyond the classroom.

## Department of Management Studies, IITM Concludes BBA Winter Training 2026

IITM Bureau

The Department of Management Studies at the Institute of Information Technology & Management (IITM) successfully concluded the 60-hour BBA In-House Industrial Training Program conducted under the Winter School Program 2026, held from 12 January to 16 January 2026. The training programme was centred on the theme “Advanced Excel & Power BI” and was designed to enhance students’ analytical and industry-ready skill sets. The intensive programme offered BBA

students hands-on exposure to industry-relevant tools widely used in business analytics and decision-making roles. Through practical sessions and guided exercises, students developed a strong foundation in data handling, analysis, and visual storytelling. During the course of the training, participants gained practical knowledge of Advanced Excel for business data analysis, including data organisation, logical functions, and analytical techniques. A major focus of the programme was Power BI, where students



learned data cleaning, transformation, and visualization methods. They were trained to create interactive dashboards and reports that support managerial decision-making. The programme also emphasized the interpretation of business data, enabling students to draw meaningful insights and present them effectively. By working on real-time scenarios, students strengthened their analytical thinking, improved, and gained confidence in handling complex datasets. This in-house industrial training played a

crucial role in bridging the gap between classroom learning and industry expectations. It equipped students with essential business analytics competencies and prepared them to meet the evolving demands of the corporate world. The Department of Management Studies extends its appreciation to all faculty

## A Day of Cinema, Craft, and Conversations for Mass Communication Students

Kartik Chandel

The School of Mass Communication witnessed an enriching and memorable day on January 24, 2026, as students were immersed in meaningful conversations around cinema, storytelling, and visual culture through interactions with some of the most respected voices in the film industry. The session opened up honest discussions on cinema as a craft, the responsibility of storytellers, and the evolving relationship between filmmakers and audi-

ences. Students had the opportunity to ask questions, reflect on the screening, and gain insights drawn from decades of experience in Indian cinema. Adding historical depth to the day, Neville Tuli, noted curator and cultural theorist, conducted an insightful session on the history of cinematography. Tracing the evolution of visual language in films, he explored how technological shifts, artistic movements, and cultural contexts have shaped the way stories are told on

screen. The session encouraged students to view cinema not just as entertainment, but as an evolving art form rooted in history and ideology. The industry perspective was further strengthened by cinematographer Hemant Chaturvedi, known for his work in landmark films such as Company and Maqbool. He shared his professional journey, spoke about the relationship between directors and cinematographers, and highlighted the importance of visual storytelling.



## UGC Equity Regulations 2026 Spark Online Backlash Over Definition of Caste Discrimination

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*Bhavya Aneja*

On January 24, 2026, the University Grants Commission (UGC) introduced a new set of rules under the Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions Regulations, 2026, following directions from the Supreme Court. These regulations aim to establish a formal system for addressing complaints and supporting disadvantaged groups in universities and colleges across India. The rules stem from petitions filed by the mothers of Rohith Vemula and Payal Tadvi. Under the new framework, all higher education institutions are required to set up an Equal Opportunity Centre. These centres

will work closely with civil society organisations, faculty and staff, local media, district authorities, and police departments. They will also coordinate with District and State Legal Services Authorities to help students access legal assistance when required. Each Equal Opportunity Centre will be formed under the supervision of the institution's head and will include representation from Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Other Backward Classes (OBCs), Persons with Disabilities (PwDs), and women. The centre's responsibilities include implementing equity-related policies,



offering academic and financial guidance to students from disadvantaged backgrounds, and acting as a link between institutions, authorities, and social organisations. However, the new regulations have triggered widespread criticism on social media, particularly over how the term “caste-based discrimination” has been defined. According to

the regulations, caste-based discrimination refers specifically to discrimination against members of SCs, STs, and OBCs on the basis of caste or tribe. This definition has led to significant backlash online, with many users arguing that it unfairly targets students from the general category. The hashtag #ShameOnUGC has been trending on the

social media platform X, with users expressing concerns that the regulations could create an atmosphere of fear and division on campuses. Some people believe the new equity rules unfairly treat general category students as guilty by default. They fear the committees could be misused to settle personal grudges or harm academic careers. Critics also say the rules are unclear and do not properly protect against false complaints. Because of these concerns, the UGC regulations have become a major topic of debate about fairness, merit, and equality in India's higher education system.

## IIM Ahmedabad to Begin Final Placements for PGP Batch from February 3

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*IITM Bureau*

The Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad (IIM Ahmedabad) announced on January 27, 2026, that its final placement process for the 2025–26 PGP batch will begin on February 3. The process will be conducted in three stages for postgraduate programme students. IIM Ahmedabad uses a cluster-based placement system, where companies are grouped according to their industries and invited to campus in phases.

The first cluster will take place on February 3, followed by the second on February 6 and the third on February 9. If needed, placements may continue through a rolling process after these dates. The final



placement process for the Post Graduate Programme in Food and Agri-Business Management (PGP-FABM) will also start on February 3. The next two clusters for this programme are scheduled for February 6 and February 9, and a rolling process may be followed later if required. Earlier, the summer placement process for the PGP (MBA) Class of 2027 and the PGP-FABM Class of 2027 concluded on November 3, 2025. More than

50 new companies took part in the summer placements, and many regular recruiters offered more job roles than before. The PGP-FABM summer placements saw participation from over 35 companies from sectors such as agriculture, FMCG, consulting and related fields. In total, 410 students were placed during the PGP summer placements, with more than 165 companies offering over 230 roles. Consulting firms made

the highest number of offers, accounting for around 40 per cent of all placements. This was followed by the banking and financial services sector. FMCG and consumer goods companies, large business groups and retail firms also offered several roles. The institute stated that it remains committed to maintaining a transparent and efficient placement process while ensuring a wide range of opportunities for students across sectors.

With strong participation from both legacy recruiters and new organisations, the upcoming final placements are expected to reflect continued industry confidence in the talent pool at Indian Institute of Manage

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On January 27, 2026, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) announced plans to introduce a new model of schools called 'MCD Shri Schools', inspired by the Centre's PM Shri Schools and the Delhi government's CM Shri Schools. According to the civic body, two Shri Schools will be set up in each MCD zone in the first phase, with admissions aimed at meritorious students.

Mayor Raja Iqbal Singh stated that the schools will focus on identifying student's talents and help them to develop their abilities, this will also them to prepare for higher education. He focused on the main points like education, discipline and values that are es-

## Fresh Counselling Brings Relief to 50 MBBS Aspirants in J&K

IITM Bureau

In a major relief for 50 MBBS students affected by a recent decision of the National Medical Commission, the Jammu and Kashmir Board of Professional Entrance Examinations has announced on January 24, 2026 as a fresh date for counselling. The move will allow the students to be accommodated in seven government-run medical colleges across the Union Territory. Earlier this month, the Medical Assessment and Rating Board of the NMC withdrew the Letter of Permission (LoP) granted to the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Institute of Medical Excellence (SMVDIME), Katra, citing non-compliance

with minimum standards. Following the withdrawal, the NMC directed that students already admitted to the institute be adjusted in other medical colleges in Jammu and Kashmir against supernumerary seats. The inaugural batch at SMVDIME comprised 50 students, including 42 Muslim students mostly from Kashmir, seven Hindu students from Jammu, and one Sikh candidate. The composition of the batch had led to protests and demands from some quarters to cancel the admissions and reserve the seats for Hindu students. According to a notification issued by BOPEE Controller of Examinations Gurvinder Raj Verma,

the 50 supernumerary seats will be allotted strictly on the basis of NEET-UG merit and the preferences given by the candidates. The seats will be distributed among seven newly established government medical colleges in the Union Territory. As per the allocation plan, eight students will be accommodated at Government Medical College, Anantnag, while seven students each will be allotted seats at GMCs in Baramulla, Doda, Rajouri, and Udhampur. The notification stated that BOPEE will conduct a physical round of counselling to reallocate students who were provisionally admitted to SMVDIME during earlier rounds.

## New 'Shri School's Model for Meritorious Student's



mary School in Ashok Vihar Phase 1, where the Mayor unfurled the national flag. The event was chaired by local councillor and Education Committee chairman Yogesh Verma. The 'Shri Schools' model draws inspiration from the Union government's PM Schools for Rising India (PM SHRI) initiative, launched in 2022 to upgrade selected schools into model institutions aligned with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, with a focus on modern infrastructure, experiential learning and holistic development. Similarly, the Delhi government's CM Shri Schools aim to strengthen foundational learning and provide enhanced facilities in select government schools.

sential for building a strong society and described teachers as key contributors in shaping young minds. MCD Education Committee chairman Yogesh Verma said that the special attention is being given to find out talented students in MCD-run schools.

Moreover, he added that 100 outstanding Class 5 students will be selected every year, and their academic, sports or co-curricu-

lar achievements will be displayed on the Corporation's website which will help other schools to recognise and admit those students. Verma also said the MCD is strengthening facilities such as mid-day meals, school uniforms and basic infrastructure, along with academic improvements. The announcement was made during the Republic Day flag hoisting ceremony at an MCD Pri-

शिक्षा में आर्टिफिशियल इंटेलिजेंस का विस्तार: कौशल-आधारित अधिगम, भाषाई समावेशन, शिक्षक सशक्तिकरण और नैतिक उपयोग के बीच नई संभावनाएँ व चुनौतियाँ

डॉ. रजनेश कुमार पाण्डेय

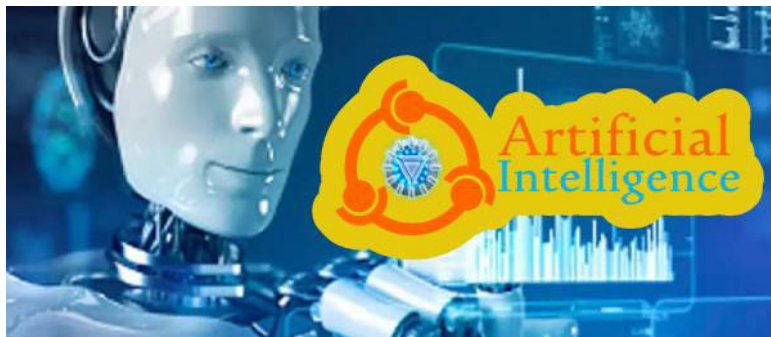
शिक्षा में आर्टिफिशियल इंटेलीजेंस का तात्पर्य केवल स्वचालन से नहीं है बल्कि मानवीय निगरानी एवं निर्णय को बनाए रखते हुए मशीन लर्निंग, डाटा एनालिटिक्स व बुद्धिमान प्रणालियों के उपयोग से है। इसका उद्देश्य शिक्षण, अधिगम, मूल्यांकन, अनुसंधान एवं शैक्षिक प्रशासन को अधिक प्रभावी, समावेशी व उत्तरदायी बनाना है। आज समस्त विश्व में शिक्षा के क्षेत्र में एआई का तेज़ी से विस्तार हो रहा है। अनुमान है कि उच्च शिक्षा के 80% से अधिक संस्थान सीखने और अनुसंधान में किसी-न-किसी रूप में एआई उपकरणों का

उपयोग कर रहे हैं। भारत में भी राष्ट्रीय शिक्षा नीति-2020 और एआई फॉर साइंस जैसी पहले डिजिटल और एआई-सक्षम शिक्षण को बढ़ावा दे रही हैं। यूनेस्को एवं आर्थिक सहयोग एवं विकास संगठन (OECD) ने तो एआई को सतत विकास लक्ष्य-4 (गुणवत्तापूर्ण शिक्षा) प्राप्त करने का एक प्रमुख माध्यम माना है। पर्सनलाइज्ड लर्निंग की आवश्यकता की अगर बात करें तो, भारत की शिक्षा प्रणाली 25 करोड़ से अधिक शिक्षार्थियों को सेवा देती है। सामाजिक, भाषाई एवं संज्ञानात्मक विविधता के इस परिदृश्य में एक ही मॉडल सभी के लिए प्रभावी

नहीं हो सकता है। एआई इसी चुनौती का समाधान प्रस्तुत करता है। उदाहरण के तौर पर, दीक्षा प्लेटफॉर्म एआई-आधारित अनुशंसा प्रणालियों के माध्यम से छात्रों को उनकी सीखने की गति और जरूरतों के अनुसार सामग्री उपलब्ध कराता है। कई पिछड़े क्षेत्रों में आज भी स्कूलों में शिक्षकों की कमी लगातार बनी हुई है, विशेषकर महत्वाकांक्षी और ग्रामीण जिलों में शिक्षक-अभाव शिक्षा की गुणवत्ता को प्रभावित करता है। उत्तर प्रदेश की SwiftChat AI जैसी पहलें पैरा-टीचरों को पाठ योजना और संदेह समाधान में सहायता देकर इस कमी को आंशिक रूप से दूर कर रही हैं।



कौशल एवं पाठ्यक्रम के बीच अंतर : वर्तमान अर्थव्यवस्था को विश्लेषणात्मक, डिजिटल एवं समस्या-समाधान कौशल चाहिए, जबकि शिक्षा प्रणाली अभी भी काफी हद तक रटने पर आधारित है। अटल टिकिंग लैब्स में एआई मॉड्यूल छात्रों में कंप्यूटेशनल थिंकिंग विकसित करने का प्रयास कर रहे हैं। जबकि भाषाई



व क्षेत्रीय बाधाएं गुणवत्तापूर्ण शिक्षा में असमानता पैदा करती हैं। लेकिन AI4Bharat जैसी पहलें उन्नत STEM सामग्री को भारतीय भाषाओं में उपलब्ध कराकर इस अंतर को कम कर रही हैं। आर्टिफिशियल इंटेलिजेंस (AI) ने शिक्षा के क्षेत्र में व्यापक परिवर्तन किए हैं और यह सीखने की प्रक्रिया को अधिक

व्यक्तिगत, प्रभावी और सुलभ बना रहा है। AI आधारित प्रणालियाँ प्रत्येक छात्र की क्षमता, रुचि और सीखने की गति का विश्लेषण कर उसी अनुरूप अध्ययन सामग्री प्रदान करती हैं, जिससे तेज और धीमे दोनों प्रकार के छात्रों को समान रूप से लाभ मिलता है। स्मार्ट टीचिंग टूल्स जैसे वर्चुअल टीचर, चैटबॉट्स

और स्मार्ट क्लासरूम छात्रों की समस्याओं का त्वरित समाधान करते हैं और शिक्षकों के कार्यभार को भी कम करते हैं। मूल्यांकन और परीक्षाओं के क्षेत्र में AI ऑटोमैटिक टेस्ट चैकिंग, असाइनमेंट मूल्यांकन और प्रदर्शन विश्लेषण में मदद करता है, जिससे समय की बचत होती है और निष्पक्ष परिणाम सुनिश्चित होते हैं। AI आधारित लर्निंग प्लेटफॉर्म 24x7 सीखने की सुविधा प्रदान करते हैं, जिससे छात्र अपनी सुविधा के अनुसार वीडियो, क्विज़ और अभ्यास सामग्री का उपयोग कर सकते हैं। इसके अतिरिक्त, AI दिव्यांग और विशेष आवश्यकता वाले छात्रों के लिए टेक्स्ट-टू-स्पीच,

स्पीच-टू-टेक्स्ट और विजुअल सपोर्ट जैसे सहायक उपकरण उपलब्ध कराता है, जिससे समावेशी शिक्षा को बढ़ावा मिलता है। शिक्षकों के लिए भी AI एक सहायक भूमिका निभाता है, क्योंकि यह पाठ योजना बनाने, छात्रों की प्रगति का विश्लेषण करने और कमजोर क्षेत्रों की पहचान करने में मदद करता है। "इस प्रकार, आर्टिफिशियल इंटेलिजेंस शिक्षा को केवल तकनीकी रूप से आधुनिक नहीं बना रहा है, बल्कि इसे अधिक व्यक्तिगत, समावेशी, गुणवत्तापूर्ण और भविष्य की आवश्यकताओं के अनुरूप बनाकर शिक्षा व्यवस्था में एक क्रांतिकारी परिवर्तन ला रहा है।



R Madhavan on receiving Padma Shri: It's not just an award but responsibility

Anjali Yadav

Actor R Madhavan, who was among 131 individuals recognised with Padma Awards 2026, said it's not just an award for him but a responsibility, and he will carry the honour with "dignity, sincerity, and a deep sense of commitment". He was awarded with Padma Shri, India's fourth-highest civilian honour, for his contributions to Indian cinema. "I accept the Padma Shri with profound gratitude and humility. This honour, bestowed upon me, is beyond my wildest dreams, and I receive it on behalf of my entire family, whose constant support and faith have been my greatest

strength," Madhavan said in a statement. The "Rang De Basanti" actor also thanked his family, mentors and fans. "This recognition is possible only because of the blessings of my mentors, the goodwill of my well-wishers, the love and encouragement of the public... Each of them has played an invaluable role in shaping my journey and guiding me toward this moment...I consider this not just an award, but a responsibility," he said. "I promise to carry this honor with dignity, sincerity, and a deep sense of commitment to the values it represents. My heart is filled with gratitude for this extraordinary



endorsement and validation, and I hope to continue serving with integrity, and dedication in the years to come," he added. Besides Madhavan, singer Alka Yagnik, Malayalam superstar Mammooty and Bollywood veteran. who was posthumously awarded with the Padma Vibhushan, were among the awardees. The Padma Awards are

among India's highest civilian honours, which are announced on the eve of Republic Day every year to acknowledge exceptional service in various disciplines. This year, 131 awardees — five Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan and 113 Padma Shri — were announced. Madhavan's latest work is "Dhurandhar", where he starred alongside

Ranveer Singh, Akshaye Khanna, Sanjay Dutt, Sara Arjun and Gaurav Gera. The film was directed by Aditya Dhar and released in December, 2025. The second part of the film is set to released in December, 2025. The second part of the film is set to release in theatres on March 19. The Padma Shri recognition marks yet another milestone in Madhavan's illustrious career spanning over two decades across Hindi, Tamil and other regional cinema industries. Known for his versatility and impactful performances, the actor has consistently balanced mainstream commercial success with critically acclaimed roles.

Mammooty, Mohanlal starrer 'Patriot' set to hit theatres in April

Bhavya Aneja

Malayalam cinema icons Mammooty and Mohanlal are set to share screen space in the upcoming film Patriot, which is slated for a theatrical release in April. The announcement has generated immense excitement among fans, as collaborations between the two legendary actors are rare and highly anticipated events in Indian cinema. According to reports, "Patriot" is expected to be a high-octane drama with strong emotional and patriotic themes. While the makers have kept detailed plot elements under wraps, early buzz suggests that the film will explore themes of duty, sacrifice, and national

pride, with both actors portraying powerful and layered characters. The project is being positioned as a major cinematic event, bringing together two of the most celebrated performers in the industry. The film is said to be mounted on a grand scale, with an emphasis on compelling storytelling, striking visuals, and impactful performances.

Industry observers note that the pairing of Mammooty and Mohanlal is likely to draw audiences across regions, given their immense popularity and decades-long contribution to Indian cinema. Fans have already taken to social media to express excitement, calling the

collaboration a "historic reunion." Beyond its commercial prospects, "Patriot" is also expected to appeal to audiences seeking meaningful storytelling combined with large-scale entertainment. The film's themes are likely to resonate with viewers looking for narratives that balance action with emotional depth.

As anticipation builds ahead of its April release, "Patriot" is already being viewed as one of the most awaited films in Malayalam cinema.

With two legendary actors joining forces, the project promises to deliver a memorable cinematic experience, drawing audiences to theatres.

Aamir Khan joins thousands of runners at Tata Mumbai Marathon 2026, calls city's spirit "amazing"

Bhavya Aneja

Bollywood actor Aamir Khan and his family are set to participate as part of the Home Run Squad at the Tata Mumbai Marathon 2026 in January, lending their support to the Paani Foundation and Agatsu Foundation. According to a press release, the family's participation highlights their continued commitment to social causes and community engagement through sport. Khan will be joined by ex-wife Kiran Rao, son Azad Rao Khan, and daughter Ira Khan in the Dream Run (5.9 km). Meanwhile, Ju-naid Khan will participate in the Open 10K category, and Ira's husband Nupur Shi-



khare will take on the challenge of the full 42K marathon. Their collective participation reflects a shared family effort to raise awareness and encourage public involvement in meaningful causes. Founded by Aamir Khan and Kiran Rao, Paani Foundation has been instrumental in transforming drought-hit villages across Maharashtra by promot-

ing water conservation through training, scientific methods, and community teamwork. On the other hand, Agatsu Foundation, established by Ira Khan, works to make mental health care more accessible, affordable, and compassionate. The organisation runs a free community centre and a low-cost therapy clinic in Bandra, along with programmes

aimed at spreading mental health awareness. Announcing the news on Instagram, Azad said, "We are running the Tata Mumbai Marathon," while Ira described them as "one big chaotic family." Aamir later joined the announcement, sharing that he had already begun training. Both foundations believe lasting change is possible when communities take ownership of solutions whether by helping farmers understand their land or enabling individuals to better understand their minds. The event featured multiple race categories, including the full marathon, half marathon, and the popular Dream Run.

Bhavya Aneja

Kristen Stewart, best known for her role in the The Twilight Saga, has sparked conversation after saying that actresses in the film industry are often "treated like puppets." Her remarks came during a recent interview where she reflected on the pressures faced by women in Hollywood and the expectations placed on their image and behaviour. Stewart spoke candidly about the lack of autonomy many actresses experience, particularly early in their careers, when decisions about their appearance, roles, and public persona are often shaped by industry demands. She suggested that the pressure to conform to certain standards can



make performers feel controlled rather than creatively empowered. According to her, the situation is gradually improving, but challenges still remain. The actor emphasised the importance of having creative control and being able to make independent choices. She noted that over time she has become more selective about the projects she takes on, prioritising roles that allow her to express herself authentically. Stewart

also highlighted how conversations around gender equality and representation have encouraged more actors to speak openly about their experiences. Her comments have resonated with many in the industry, with supporters saying they reflect long-standing concerns about how women are perceived and managed in entertainment. At the same time, the remarks have reignited broader discussions about workplace culture, power

dynamics, and the need for more inclusive practices in film-making. Stewart has long been vocal about artistic freedom and challenging traditional norms in Hollywood. With her latest comments, she has once again drawn attention to the evolving conversation around gender, creativity, and respect for performers, underlining the need for continued progress toward a more equitable industry environment.

Son of Satish Shah Expresses Gratitude as Veteran Actor Receives Prestigious Padma Shri Honour

Anjali Yadav

The son of veteran actor Satish Shah has expressed heartfelt gratitude after his father was honoured with the prestigious Padma Shri, one of India's highest civilian honours. The recognition celebrates Shah's decades-long contribution to Indian cinema and television, where he became a beloved figure known for his versatility, impeccable comic timing, and memorable character roles that resonated with audiences across generations.

In a public statement, Shah's son thanked the Government of India and well-wishers for acknowledging his father's artistic legacy. He described the honour as a proud and emotional moment for the family, saying the award reflects the love and respect his father has received throughout his career. He added that his father always believed in the power of storytelling and remained deeply committed to his craft, regardless of the size or scale of the role. Satish Shah has been a familiar face for de-



cades, appearing in numerous films, television shows, and stage productions. Known for bringing warmth, humour, and authenticity to his performances, he built a reputation as one of the most

dependable character actors in the industry. The recognition highlights not only his artistic achievements but also his contribution to shaping popular entertainment in India. The family expressed

hope that the honour will inspire younger artists to pursue their passion with dedication and humility. Shah's son said the award is not just a personal milestone but also a celebration of

the many collaborators, writers, directors, and audiences who supported his father's journey over the years. He noted that the recognition belongs equally to everyone who contributed to his father's success. Reflecting on his father's work ethic, he shared that Shah always valued discipline, professionalism, and mutual respect on set. These qualities, he said, helped him sustain a long and successful career in a competitive industry and earned him admiration from colleagues

and fans alike. Members of the film and television fraternity have also shared congratulatory messages, recalling Shah's generosity, humility, and ability to create a positive atmosphere during shoots. Many described him as an artist who uplifted those around him with his humour and kindness, leaving a lasting impression on everyone he worked with. The Padma awards are announced annually to recognise distinguished service in various fields, including arts, literature,

science, and public affairs. For the Shah family, the honour stands as a reminder of a lifetime dedicated to creativity, perseverance, and excellence. As tributes continue to pour in, the recognition further cements Satish Shah's place among the respected figures of Indian entertainment. His son's message of gratitude reflects both pride and humility, underscoring the significance of the award as a celebration of a remarkable artistic journey that continues to inspire aspiring performers and admirers across the country.



## RCB Clinch WPL Title After Thrilling Win Over Delhi Capitals

IITM Bureau

Chasing the biggest total in a Women's Premier League final, she seized the chase, strangled the middle overs with the assurance of someone who knew the game was hers. With a 41-ball 87, she played a captain's knock, completing a historic chase and helping Royal Challengers Bengaluru win their second WPL title in three years. For the first time in franchise cricket history, the men's and women's units of a franchise hold the trophies in

## Kishan and Suryakumar lay down marker in astonishing chase

IITM Bureau

Ishan Kishan and Suryakumar Yadav produced a commanding batting display to power their side to a remarkable run chase, sending a strong message to the rest of the competition. On January 23, 2026, while chasing a challenging target, the duo took control early, blending aggression with composure to dismantle the opposition bowling attack. Kishan set the tempo with fluent strokeplay, while Suryakumar complemented him with his



both WPL and IPL. It may seem like it, but RCB did not bludgeon their way to a six-wicket win over Delhi Capitals. They built it through a ruthless 165-run partnership between Smriti Mandhana and Georgia Voll. Before the final, Voll

told reporters that the teams that succeed are the teams that do the simple things (better) for longer periods of time. And since she entered in the second over, she put on a display of clean-striking during her 79 off 54. RCB were jolted ear-

ly, having lost Grace Harris for just nine. Voll, who hadn't had the most consistent seasons, decided to take matters into her own hands. She raced to 50 in 37 balls while Mandhana was happy to play second fiddle. But as soon as she

locked in, she looked the most aggressive she has in the format. In an innings laced with 12 boundaries and three sixes, she eventually finished with a strike rate of 212.2. Voll had already found her touch but Mandhana soon caught up to her. DC seemed to have found an opening in the backend, dismissing Voll, Richa Ghosh (6) and Mandhana in back to back overs. RCB needed 10 in the final over but Radha Yadav and Nadine de Klerk held their nerves to seal the game with two balls remaining.

## India Open Super 750: Indian Shuttlers Fall Short of Semifinals

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*Kartik Chandel*

India's campaign at the India Open Super 750 came to a disappointing end on Friday, January 19, 2026, as none of the home players managed to progress beyond the quarterfinal stage, leaving the host nation without representation in the semifinals of the prestigious BWF World Tour tournament. Despite strong crowd support at the KD Jadhav Indoor Hall, Indian shuttlers struggled to convert opportunities against higher-ranked and in-form interna-



tional opponents. Several matches witnessed close contests, but decisive moments went in favour of visiting players, highlighting gaps in consistency and match temperament. In singles and doubles categories alike, Indian players showed flashes of promise but failed

to sustain pressure during crucial phases of their matches. The quarterfinal exits underlined concerns over depth, experience, and execution under high-stakes conditions. The early conclusion of India's challenge has prompted reflection on preparation and

performance, particularly with major international tournaments approaching. With no Indian presence in the semifinals, the tournament now moves into its final stages dominated by overseas contenders, while the focus shifts to rebuilding momentum for the upcoming BWF World Tour events. The outcome also raises questions about India's ability to capitalize on home advantage in top-tier tournaments. With the Paris Olympic cycle entering a crucial phase, the performances at the India

## Bangladesh firm on not playing T20 World Cup in India despite risk of exclusion

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*IITM Bureau*

A day after Bangladesh were told by the ICC that they would be replaced at the upcoming T20 World Cup if they continued to refuse to play in India, Bangladesh have remained firm in wanting their matches moved to Sri Lanka. "Let me tell you clearly. It is the government's decision not to play in India due to security concerns," Bangladesh's sports adviser Asif Nazrul said on Thursday January 22, 2026. The BCB said it would keep communicating with the ICC on the issue. This decision, announced after a meeting in Dhaka between Nazrul, BCB president Aminul Islam and CEO Nizamuddin, and several national team players, means they risk not participating in the tournament beginning on February 7. Nurul Hasan, Shamim Hossain, Hasan Mahmud, Najmul Hossain Shanto, Jaker Ali, Tanzid Hasan and Saif



Hassan were among the cricketers present. ESPNcricinfo understands the prevailing sentiment among the players was that they wanted to play the World Cup. "The security threat is not a theory. It is a real incident," Nazrul said, referencing Mustafizur Rahman's removal from the IPL. "The BCCI bowed down to pressure from fundamental groups, and kicked him out of their tournament. The ICC tournament is being held in India where the BCCI can't give security to one of our players. It will be the responsibility of their

security agencies. How can we be convinced that they can provide security to our cricketers, fans and journalists? The ICC hasn't even tried to convince us. They only talked about their standard security plan, rather than address our specific grievance. The India government didn't even try to convince us. They didn't call the Mustafiz incident an isolated incident. They didn't say sorry about the Mustafiz incident, or even try to communicate with us. So there's no scope for changing our decision. We didn't get justice

from the ICC; they are still not allowing us to play in Sri Lanka. There are many instances that the venue has been changed due to security risk. We are hopeful the ICC will take into account our genuine concern, and give us the opportunity to play in the World Cup. Players attending the meeting were given the floor briefly and all were in favour of playing at the T20 World Cup. A number of them went in feeling the government's decision was a foregone conclusion. They are believed to have made the case that the event

is a big opportunity for players. But both government officials and the BCB did not budge from their stance. Bangladesh is currently in Group C along with England, Italy, West Indies and Nepal, and are scheduled to play their first three games in Kolkata and their last one in Mumbai. They play West Indies on February 7, the opening day of the tournament. On Wednesday, after an ICC board meeting, the ICC had formally rejected Bangladesh's request to play their matches in Sri Lanka instead of India on grounds of security and gave them 24 hours to speak to their government and get back. The issue of security arose after the BCCI instructed Kolkata Knight Riders to release Mustafizur from their IPL 2026 squad. Although no reason was stated for that directive, it came amid deteriorating relations between India and Bangladesh.

## Ranchi Royals Down SG Pipers in League Clash

IITM Bureau

Ranchi Royals signed off their Hockey India League campaign on a positive note with an emphatic 5-2 victory over table-toppers SG Pipers on January 8, 2026, who had already sealed their place in the final, in a league-stage encounter on Sunday. With nothing to lose, the Royals played with freedom and intent, unsettling the otherwise consistent SG Pipers with sharp attacking play and clinical finishing. Ranchi took control early, capitalising on defensive lapses and converting key chances to build momentum. Despite resting a few regulars, SG Pipers showed flashes of quality and managed to pull back two goals, but struggled to contain Ranchi's aggressive press and quick transitions. The Royals' forwards exploited space effectively, ensuring the contest slipped out of reach for



the finalists. While the result had no bearing on the standings, the performance served as a timely reminder of Ranchi Royals' potential, even as SG Pipers shift focus to the final, where they will look to regroup and reclaim their dominance. The Royals made full use of their opportunities from penalty corners and open play, showing greater urgency throughout the match. Their midfield controlled possession effectively, allowing the forwards to apply sustained pressure and stretch the SG Pipers' defence for long periods. For SG Pipers, the defeat served as a time-

ly wake-up call ahead of the final. While their place in the title clash remains unaffected, the team will look to tighten defensive structures and sharpen finishing as they prepare for the decisive encounter. The Men's Hero Hockey India League 2025-26 concluded in dramatic fashion on January 26, with Vedanta Kalinga Lancers lifting the title after edging Ranchi Royals 3-2 in a tightly contested final at the Kalinga Hockey Stadium in Bhubaneswar. According to officials from Hockey India League, the league stage has witnessed highly competitive contests.